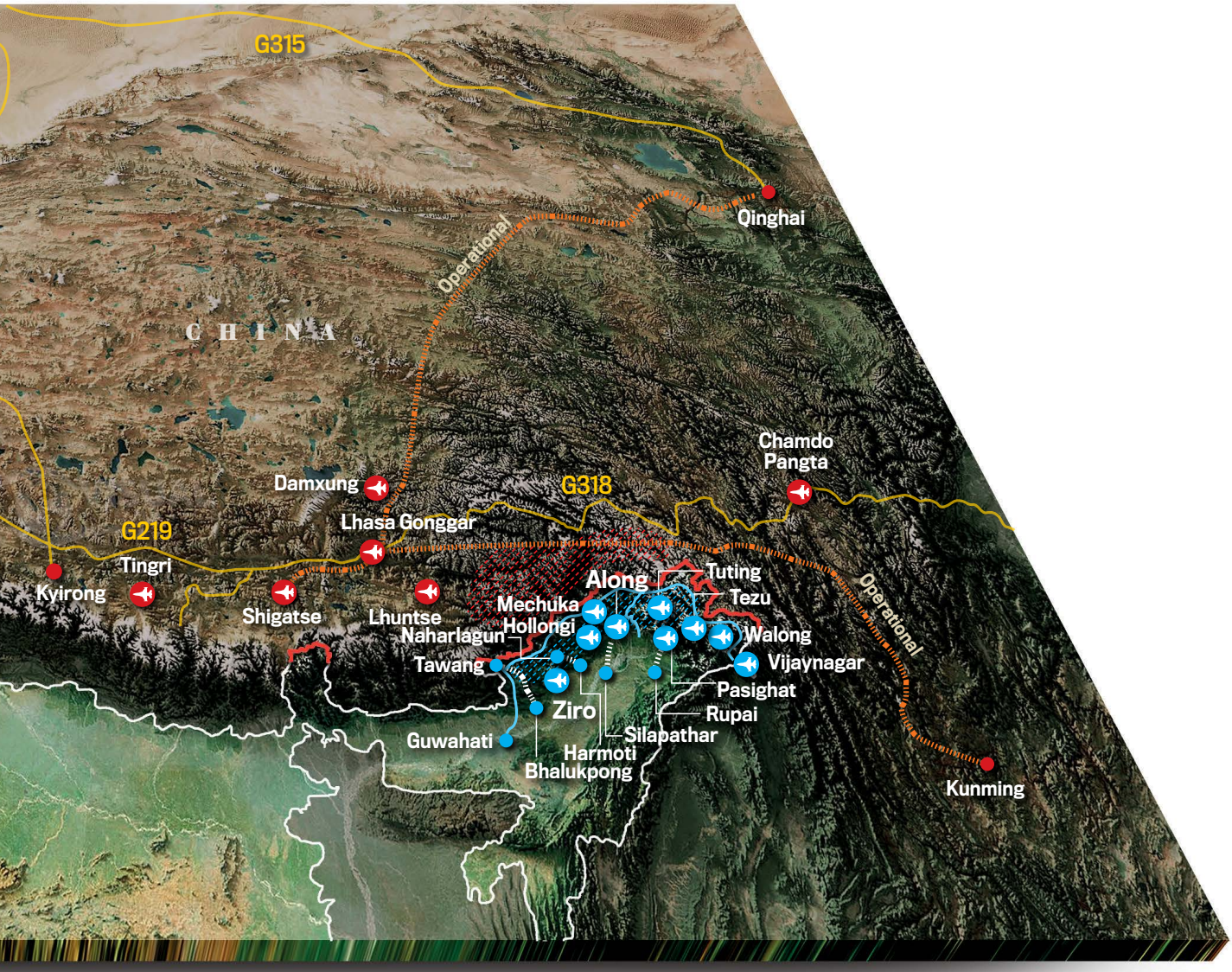


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

Due to be completed in 2035, it will traverse the length of Aksai Chin through the eastern section of Depsang plains, south past the Galwan Valley and towards Pangong Tso, a saline lake surrounded by jagged peaks and unforgiving ridgelines. "It is a strategic artery that will connect these flashpoints to mainland China and give the PLA a new supply route," Apa says.

A study by the UK-based thinktank Chatham House observes that in the Galwan Valley, a number of PLA bases are now connected by roads that lead to the main standoff site with the Indian army. In Raki Nala, a river valley south of the contested Depsang plains, Chinese outposts capable of blocking Indian patrols, are visible. At Pangong Tso, a bridge is nearing completion. When finished, it will allow the rapid deployment of Chinese forces from the PLA's Rutog military garrison.

"China's infrastructure development in border and depth areas allows for faster deployment and logistical support, while providing better control over remote, earlier unpopulated, forward areas," geospatial intelligence researcher Damien Symon tells INDIA TODAY. The proximity of these new projects to the LAC, he adds, increases the risk of inadvertent clashes.

BORDER VILLAGES, RAILWAYS

Soon after the PLA created the WTC in 2015-16, China ratcheted up tension with India, with the Doklam standoff taking place in 2017. It also started developing 'moderately prosperous', or 'Xiaokang', dual military-civilian border villages close to Arunachal Pradesh. The plan is to build 628 such villages in 112 Tibetan border towns in the Shigatse, Lhokha, Nyingchi and Ngari prefectures. China has reportedly built 354 villages with underground bunkers in the Lhokha prefecture, which shares a border with Arunachal and Bhutan.

"Well-designed border villages serve as border watchposts and help in occupying no man's land. They are to be the eyes and ears of the PLA and help China reaffirm its claims over disputed territories," says Dr Tsewang Dorji, research fellow at the Tibet Policy Institute.

As for railways, a crucial arm for mobilisation of forces, China has made public its "medium to long term railway plan" for